For The Woman Who Has Everything

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/36417358.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Horde Prime (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Finn | Adora/Catra Child (She-Ra), Angella (She-Ra), Hordak (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Canon, Post-Canon, Birthdays, For The Man Who Has Everything (DC Comics), Based on a comic book and Justice League Episode, Canon-Typical Violence, Graphic Violence, Visions, Horde Prime Returns (She-Ra), Married Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Marriage Proposal, Dreams vs. Reality, Angella Lives (She-Ra), Parasites, other characters not mentioned in tags, Alternate Universe - Canon Divergence, Nightmares, Adoruary 2022, Adoruary Future, Alternate Universe - Future, Drowning, Dismemberment, Blood and Gore, Torture, Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner's A+ Parenting

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Part 1 of For The Woman Who Has Everything

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by TheStarGayzingEtherianCollection (TheStarGayzingEtherian)

Summary

While surprising Adora on her birthday, Catra and Glimmer find their friend with a strange alien plant attached to her body, keeping her in a trance-like state. As Adora finds herself in a dream world where everything appears perfect, Catra and Glimmer have to fight against one of their oldest enemies, who has returned to take his long-awaited revenge on the saviours of Etheria. (Catradora, Canon, Angst/Hurt/Comfort, Based on the Justice League episode "For The Man Who Has Everything".)

Chapter 1

Chapter Summary

> Catra and Glimmer find Adora in the grip of an alien plant, while Adora awakens in a world that is seemingly perfect... or is it?

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter 1

Freedom, that's what Catra felt as she rode on Melog's back through the woods, hands gripping her loyal companion tightly as she leapt through the tight trees. She grinned as Melog leapt over another branch, screaming with joy. There was something about riding Melog that satisfied some primal urge within Catra.

She couldn't describe it exactly, but ever since the war had been over and Catra had been able to take things slow, she'd never felt happier, especially now that she was with Adora. Despite the pain and hardship she'd been through, she was eternally grateful to the universe for giving her this second chance.

And today, she had plans to give something back to the woman who had given her that second chance. As she and Melog rode on, Catra thought of Adora, beautiful sweet Adora.

How she had always loved her, how she'd protected her... how despite all the time they'd been apart and hated each other, she still carried that torch for her, even at the lowest of emotional lows. Their love was something that clearly would never be broken, no matter what came between them.

With their destination just over the horizon, Catra heard a grunt from her passenger, whose arms were wrapped tightly around her waist.

"Remind me why we're riding Melog instead of me teleporting us?!" Glimmer shouted, clinging onto Catra for dear life and hoping she wouldn't fall off.

"Because we're gonna surprise Adora, that's why!" Catra called back. "I mean, this is the first birthday she's had since the end of the war!"

"I know that!" Glimmer responded. "But we didn't need to ride all the way to the Crystal Castle!"

"Hey, Melog needs the exercise!" Catra stated.

Glimmer yelped as Melog leapt through the air between two very tall trees. She covered her mouth, making a motion. "Oh shit! I think I'm gonna throw up..."

"Hey, don't do it over my new outfit!" Catra urged her.

Catra had altered her appearance recently, in celebration of it being a year since the end of the war, a year of being her new better self. Her hair had managed to grow out again was now in a little ponytail and her outfit was a little more covering up of her body, with some slight gold highlights that were inspired by Adora's She-Ra armour.

Eventually, the two of them arrived at the crystal castle, the former First One's ruin where Light Hope and the Heart of Etheria had once resided. For the past few weeks, Adora, Bow, Entrapta and Hordak had been trying to salvage what they could of the remaining First One's tech, in hopes of perhaps reactivating Light Hope under her original programming.

Adora and the others had been at this for weeks, and as such, Catra wasn't surprised that Adora probably forgot today was her birthday. Then again, it had been helpful of Bow to keep Adora

busy at the First One's ruin while Catra and Glimmer prepared the birthday party back in Brightmoon.

Scorpia and Perfuma had baked a massive cake and were taking care of the decorations, while Mermista and Sea Hawk had seen to party invites. Netossa and Spinnerella were doing their usual thing of making sure Brightmoon didn't fall apart while Glimmer was gone, along with her father Micah.

Catra and Glimmer got off Melog and walked towards the ruin's entrance, entering the darkened hallway. Despite Light Hope being offline and the heart of Etheria disabled, both Catra and Glimmer still felt a sense of anxiety from within the Castle, as though they felt that not all of its sharper edges had been dulled.

As they walked, Catra saw the small wrapped present Glimmer was holding in her hands. "So... what'd you get her anyway?"

"It's a secret!" Glimmer chirped. "What did you get her? After all, it's her first birthday as your girlfriend."

Catra blushed. "Well, I..." She groaned. "She's always been the hardest to buy birthday presents for." She fumbled with something in her pocket, hoping Glimmer hadn't been able to guess what it was. "But it's something I know she'll like."

Glimmer smiled. "I'm kinda surprised you even have birthdays at all. Adora told me that you had no birthdays in the Horde."

"We didn't," Catra admitted. "But technically, today was the day Shadow Weaver took Adora in... so I guess it counts in that sense."

"In a sense," Glimmer agrees as she tailed behind Catra.

"Besides, my present is way better than yours," Catra said proudly.

"Nice try," Glimmer stated. "But mine is so much better."

Catra laughed. She loved how competitive she and Glimmer got. While they weren't enemies anymore, she loved the friendly rivalry they had. If anything... Glimmer was like the annoying sister she never knew she wanted, always teasing and playing with her.

As they entered the castle, Catra saw that Adora was nowhere to be found.

"Adora! You here!" She cried. "Adoraaaaa!"

There was no response.

"Huh, that's weird," Catra admitted.

"Everything feels kinda quiet in here," Glimmer added. "A little too quiet if you ask me." She cleared her throat. "Adora! Bow! Are you here?"

Again no reply. Catra was starting to get worried.

"Come on, Sparkles, let's head to the central chamber. Maybe we'll find something there."

Glimmer nodded, as Catra ran down the corridor.

As the two of them entered the central chamber, however, they saw that things had taken a turn for the worse. The entire room was even more destroyed than it had been previously. The walls had the scars of battle and they saw Bow, Entrapta and Hordak pinned under rubble or leaning against the walls and pillars unconscious.

However, in the centre of the room, Glimmer and Catra saw the grimmest sight of all. Stood on the dais in the middle of the chamber, still clutching her sword, was Adora. She was transformed into her She-Ra form, but some sort of strange, purple plant-like organism was fixed to her face, covering her mouth and nose and with tentacles wrapping itself around her head.

"Oh my god!" Catra exclaimed. "Adora!"

Glimmer and Catra rushed over to Adora.

"What's wrong with her?!" Glimmer exclaimed.

Catra touched the growth on Adora's face, her eyes narrowing. She opened one of Adora's eyelids, looking into her eye. Her pupil was twitching back and forth, the telltale signs of rapid eye movement. She was clearly asleep... or at least in a state resembling sleep. Melog nuzzled against Adora, trying to stir her, but Adora didn't even budge an inch.

"Hmmm... she seems to be in some sort of trance or she's asleep," Catra stated. "This thing on her face must be keeping her like this."

"Can you get it off her?" Glimmer wondered.

"I don't think that's a good idea," Catra stated. "This thing seems to have fused itself to her. Ripping it off might hurt Adora."

Glimmer sighed and then walked over to Bow. She quickly checked his pulse, relieved when she still felt it. "Bow's not dead."

She went and checked Hordak and Entrapta, the former pinned under a collapsed pillar. They too still had their pulses, but Glimmer was still worried about what had happened here.

"Hordak and Entrapta are fine too," Glimmer stated. "Though... Hordak's missing his fusion cannon."

"That's odd, Hordak never leaves Dryl without that thing," Catra mused. "Something's not right here."

Glimmer summoned her staff. "I'm gonna check the tunnels. If whoever did this is still here, I'll find them."

"Be careful, sparkles," Catra warned. "We don't know who or what we're dealing with."

"Don't worry," Glimmer assured as her hands began to glow with magical energy. "We may not be at war, but I still know how to fight," stated before taking off towards the ancient tunnels.

As Glimmer descended towards the tunnels, Catra sat beside her beloved Adora, gently stroking her hair. "Be okay," she silently pleaded. "Please be okay."

Her gaze kept shifting to the odd plant that seemed to wrap itself around Adora's face, scowling at it. "I don't know what the hell you are, but if you harm Adora in any way, I will personally throw you into a lava pit, and screw what Perfuma might say about it!" Falling back onto her tail, she groaned. "I really wish I could see what the hell's going on in there," she bemoaned.

She grabbed the sides of the creature, trying to yank it off Adora's face, but it was as if it was glued right onto Adora's skin.

"This thing's stuck on there tight," she commented. "Adora, please, if you can hear me... Give me a sign or something. Please... I can't lose you again."

Adora's eyes fluttered open, as sunlight streaked into her bedroom. She sighed in content, feeling she was walking the fine line between being asleep and being awake. She didn't know what way she was going to go until, she then felt something lick her cheek, firmly dragging her back into the land of the living.

She giggled, opening her eyes fully. "Alright, alright... I'm up!" She looked over at Melog, the alien cat gazing at her. "Morning Melog... come to wish me a happy birthday?"

Melog just meowed and Adora heard the sound of another groan, this time to the other side of her bed. Catra rose from her slumber, rubbing her eyes and smiling adoringly at her wife, those blue and gold eyes helping Adora feel so much warmth and content at that moment.

"Good morning, sleepy cat," Adora cooed. "Up all night again I see?"

"What can I say, I'm a nocturnal animal," Catra remarked, chuckling before she yawned. She cuddled up to Adora, stroking her cheek. "Happy birthday, gorgeous."

Adora smiled fondly at her wife, pulling her close into her a kiss. But before they could let things get any more intimate, the two of them felt Melog climb onto the bed and meow loudly again.

Pulling away from the kiss, Catra sighed. "Seems like someone doesn't want us to sleep in today."

"Well, I do have to go and see Glimmer about something," Adora reminded her wife, sitting up.

Catra yawned again, stretching her arms. "Oh yeah, I remember now. Sparkles sent you the holo-mail last night."

Smiling in content, Adora leaned down and gave Catra a soft kiss on the forehead. "You can stay here if you want, my pretty kitty." Adora caressed her fur-covered wife in her own muscular arms. "I'll get up and make breakfast."

"No, babe, you can stay in bed for a few more minutes," Catra cooed, kissing Adora's cheek, relaxing in the blonde's embrace. "I'll go make you some eggs. Besides, it's your birthday, I should be the one to spoil you."

"Oh, very well," Adora accepted. "Guess I can't say no to that."

"You deserve it, birthday girl," Catra replied.

As Catra pulled herself out of bed and slipped on a rather comfortable looking robe, Adora couldn't help but watch the woman she loved with all her heart. She still wasn't sure how it came to be, but somehow, by some miracle, Adora and Catra were finally married and were living a wonderful, peaceful life together.

"What?" Catra asked, catching Adora gazing at her.

"Nothing," Adora said with a smile. "I just can't get over how beautiful you've gotten over the years."

Catra chuckled as she made her way to her wife. "What can I say, marrying you seems to have brought the best out of me." She then leaned down to kiss Adora passionately; an act that her wife quite readily reciprocated. Adora's hands wrapped around Catra's face, pulling her closer into the kiss.

"Ew! Gross!" a new voice groaned, causing both women to suddenly break from their loving kiss and turn towards their bedroom door. Standing in the frame of the door stood an eleven-year-old, felid child with sandy blonde fur, golden blonde hair, and bright blue eyes.

"You won't think that way for long, Finn," Catra said smugly after breaking her kiss with Adora. "One day, you'll find a boy or a girl who you'll want to kiss every chance you get."

"Bleegh!" Finn gaged, sticking out their tongue. "I'd rather kiss a dead fish," they stated.

"Hey, that won't be too far from kissing one of Mermista's and Seahawk's kids," Adora quipped.

"Mom!" Finn exclaimed.

"Okay, I think we've traumatized our child long enough," Catra said as she approached their child. "Don't you have anything you want to wish your mother?"

Finn put their hand to their chin, actually thinking about their mom's words. "Good luck at the royal meeting today?"

"Finn!" Catra groaned.

"I'm kidding! I'm kidding!" they quickly stated before running up to Adora and hugging her tightly. "Happy Birthday, mom."

"Thanks, sweetie," Adora said as she returned the hug.

Catra gave Adora a peck on the cheek. "Don't be gone too long. We still have a birthday of yours to celebrate."

Adora giggled. "Let me guess, secretly planning a surprise party for me?"

"What? No, I'd never," Catra joked, before giggling. "Well what if I am, I'm not gonna tell you anything am I."

"Fair point," Adora replied.

After opening a few of her birthday gifts with Finn and getting a gourmet breakfast cooked for her by Catra, Adora got herself a bath and dressed, heading out of their small little home in the Whispering Woods towards the nearby stables. As she turned around, she saw Catra and Finn having her off.

"Don't be gone too long, babe!" Catra called out to her.

"I won't!" Adora replied to her wife. "Make sure your mom stays out of trouble, Finn."

"I will!" The small blonde cat replied, as Adora headed to the stables.

As she arrived, Adora walked over to her steed Swift Wind, a beautiful stallion whom Adora had kept for years. She sighed, relishing in the content of her life. For as long as she'd known, her world had been peaceful. She was chief advisor to the Queen of Brightmoon, had a loving wife and child and best of all, today was her birthday.

Though she had wished Glimmer hadn't called that emergency meeting the night before. She knew it was a serious matter but still, on her birthday of all days?

Adora sighed, petting Swifty on the head. "I know boy, I hate this as much as you do. But hey, I'm sure it won't take long."

Bucking her horse, Adora galloped down the forest path that led away from her home. She smiled, crying out in joy as Swift Wind skipped over a small ditch in the path, giggling as she held his reigns tight. She felt a sense of elation giving into her joy as she rode through the woods.

However, as she flew through the air... something strange happened. There was a massive flash of light and for a moment... Adora saw everything was different. Swift Wind... suddenly had wings?! And they were flying over what looked like a battlefield of some kind. And as for Adora herself, she was dressed in some kind of white and gold armour with a long red cape. Adora screamed as quickly as it came, the vision faded. Unfortunately, Swift Wind too was startled.

The horse reared back and Adora fell clean off her horse, landing headfirst onto the ground below, getting herself covered in dirt and bruises.

"Ugh!" She groaned in pain as she stumbled up, wiping the hair from her eyes. She panted, vividly still recalling the images she'd just seen. "What... What was that?"

She got to her feet, wiping the dirt off her clothes. She saw Swift Wind galloping around out of control. He always did get scared easily.

"Woah, easy boy, easy!" Adora cautioned him, eventually calming him down and stroking his snout. "I know, I know, everything's okay now."

The horse just gave Adora a concerned look. She could see the fear in his eyes, a fear she shared.

"I don't... I don't know what that was either," Adora admitted. "But, I'm sure it was nothing... I hope."

Catra grunted as she tried to pry off the alien organism attached to Adora's face. She tried to unhook one of the tentacles that had

wrapped around Adora's neck, but it was no use. There was some kind of adhesive that had glued the tentacle to Adora's skin, something Catra couldn't cut through with her claws, not without hurting Adora.

"Ugh!" She groaned. "If Entrapta wasn't unconscious, she'd have figured something out by now!" She stared at Adora's face. "Come on, Adora... I don't know if you can hear me, but you need to fight this thing."

No response came from Adora.

"Great, even when you're being drugged by an alien plant, you're as dense as a rock," she groaned. "When I find the one who did this to you, I'll make them pay!"

Catra sat next to Entrapta, watching as her usually hyperactive friend dozed peacefully. "Heh," she chuckled. "This has to be the stillest I've ever seen you, Entrapta. All it took was being knocked unconcious."

She then sighed, knowing she probably should have gotten Entrapta somewhere safe first, just in case whoever did this to her came back to finish her off. But Adora came first right now. She was the one with the alien plant thing on her face, not Entrapta.

As Catra looked over at Adora, she had to wonder... Adora didn't look in any pain or discomfort, despite having some bruises on her body. "Got to say, whatever that, thing, on your face is, you seem pretty relaxed with it. I guess whoever put this thing on you did it without you realising or something."

As she did so, she feels her present shifting in her pocket. She reaches into her back pocket, pulling out a small black velvet box, no bigger than a book of matches. Looking down at the box, a smile blooms on her face.

"Hey, 'trapta, can you keep a secret?" Catra whispered. "Today is Adora's birthday, and not to brag, but I think I have the best present ever for her, no matter what Sparkles thinks." She

brought the box close to Entrapta's face, and flips the lid open. Inside the box, on a velvet red pillow, sat a beautiful white gold ring, with a single beautiful crystal sitting on the centre of it.

"It took me God knows how long to scrounge up the money to get this thing. Hell, the gem alone cost me a fortune. You know it's something they're naming after Adora? It's some new crystal that sprung up after she did the whole setting the magic free thing."

Catra groaned, realising Entrapta wasn't listening. "Ugh, I can't wait any longer! I have to do it now! When everyone wakes up and that stupid plants are mulch, I'm going to run up to Adora, kiss her like I never kissed her before, fall on one knee, and beg her to marry me." She then turned to her still unconscious friend. "And if you so much as breath a word of this to Adora, I will personally shave you bald, got it?"

No response from Entrapta, as expected.

"Yeah, that's what I thought," Catra murmured.

Suddenly, Catra heard a sinister chuckling, which made her get to her feet again. Melog looked around, her mane tensing up and glowing red, along with with her eyes.

"W-What was that?" Catra wondered. "Sparkles? Is that you?"

The chuckling was heard again, as thunderous footsteps approached Catra.

"Sparkles, this ain't funny!" Catra argued. "This is no time to be fooling around!"

"Oh, but it is most assuredly the time for a reunion..." a cold, ruthless voice then rasped.

"Reunion... what..." Catra's eyes widened, as she realised who that menacing voice belonged to. A voice that haunted Catra's nightmares every single night. "No... No... Not you!"

Catra gasped and then looked at one of the open doors to her left. Through the shadows, Catra saw the outline of a tall figure, dragging something behind them, four green eyes glowing sinisterly. She quickly got in front of Adora, sharpening her claws, wanting to protect her.

The figure revealed itself... and it was none other than Horde Prime. The alien tyrant stood before Catra, in one hand holding an unconscious and bruised Glimmer and in the other, wielding Hordak's fusion cannon. His appearence was somewhat different, noticeably lacking his coat and instead having a greatly increased muscle mass. With his new size, he practically towered over Catra and Adora,

"Hello, little sister," Prime greeted her menacingly. "It's been a while."

Catra's jaw dropped. "No... No, that's impossible!"

Horde Prime chuckled. "Your eyes are not deceiving you, little sister."

Catra growled. "You're dead! I saw it happen!"

"I am not so easily destroyed, Catra," Prime remarked. "And now that you are here... I think it's time I finally got my long-awaited revenge."

Chapter End Notes

> Hello again everyone! This is my little gift to our beloved Adora for her birthday, an adaptation of the famous Superman story "For The Man Who Has Everything". This story is going to be very damn angsty, fair warning, but I hope you will all love it. I will post the last chapter of it on Adora's birthday.
>
> If you liked the fic please be sure to comment!

Chapter 2

Chapter Summary

> Catra and Glimmer confront Horde Prime, while Adora's world starts to unravel.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter 2

Catra stared in horror as Prime walked closer and closer to her, his towering form casting a looming shadow over her. The memories flashed back in her mind, his sinister laughter, him forcing that damned chip into the back of her neck, electrocuting her in his baptism pool to punish her.

How could this monster, this sick, vile creature be back from the dead? And more importantly, how was she going to save Adora? Prime definitely looked a lot more powerful now, what with those muscles and Hordak's cannon on his arm. Yes, Catra had faced large opponents before... but she knew how Prime studied his opponents and knew their every move.

Prime chuckled, the sound of his voice echoing through the chamber. "I would have waited an eternity for this. Finally, I now have a chance to correct my greatest error."

"How are you even alive!" Catra demanded, unsheathing her claws. "You're supposed to be dead!"

Horde Prime laughed. "I saved a backup of my consciousness into one of my many clones. When my mind was erased by She-Ra's magic, the backup automatically activated. Of course, it took some time for that clone to fully metamorphose into my new

form, but now that I have returned, I won't let anything stop me from sharing my light with the universe."

"You certainly haven't gotten any prettier, that's for certain," Catra tried to snark, as the much bulkier Prime strode over to her and Adora, dropping Glimmer down beside them.

Another sinister cackle. "Trying to deflect your fear with humour. I can read you like a book, Catra. I know you're scared, your pupils dilated. It's rather noble how even when your dear Adora is immobilised, you still try to protect her."

"Yeah, so very predictable, I remember your catchphrase," Catra remarked. "Just tell me what you've done to her!"

The overlord smirked, walking over to Adora and running one of his clawed fingers against the edge of the creature wrapped around her face. "I knew that if I was to try and fight against you and Adora again, Catra, I needed to be better prepared. Which is why I've spent the last year or so perfecting my current form." He flexed his muscles. "I needed to hone my body as well as my mind, which is why I absorbed the genetic material from dozens of my brothers to attain my current strength."

Catra's eyes widened. She'd heard stories about various Horde Clones going missing over the last year. They'd never found a culprit... or any bodies, until now. "You murdered your own brothers?! Just so you could get a bit of an edge on Adora?"

"Those clones were easily disposable," Prime remarked. "Besides, they're all damn traitors to me now ever since they fell under my little brother's sway." He gazed at Hordak's unconscious form. "Another error I'll soon correct."

"But even so, getting some bigger abs doesn't make much of a difference. Adora would be no match against you even with that extra strength. At full power, she's strong enough to crack a planet in half." Catra's eyes widened. "But you realised that didn't you."

"Correct, so then I remembered what happened right before my death... how I sensed the systems of this decrepit place give her a vision of the future. A beautiful wish indeed... which gave me an idea. What if I turned that beautiful wish... into a perfect little prison."

Catra's eyes widened before she snarled. "You sick fuck!"

Prime laughed lightly. "It's a marvellous work of nature this creature. The organism feeds off the lifeforce of other beings while keeping them in a trance. It shows them a vision of their perfect world, one that the host would never want to leave." He smiled. "I wonder if it's giving Adora an even more beautiful future than she had before. Well, I'm sure she'll love it. I plan on keeping her like this forever, as a reminder of what happens to those who defy me!"

"You took Adora's happiness... and you're twisting it against her. You're violating her like you did with me!" Catra's pupils narrowed in primal rage, as she bared her claws. "This time, I'm gonna make sure you're dead, because I'm gonna gut you myself, you bastard!" She then leapt out at Prime, lunging at full strength.

Prime glared, raising the fusion cannon on his arm and then blasting Catra. The catgirl was knocked back, smacking into a nearby wall. Prime strode over to Catra, grabbing her with his free hand. As his metallic claws dug into Catra's neck, he glared at her menacingly with his four, glowing eyes.

"I should have just killed you when I had the chance, Catra," Prime remarked, as he squeezed Catra's neck with all his strength. "Keeping you alive was yet another mistake I shall now correct. A pity Adora can't hear the sound of your screaming when I snap your pitiful neck."

Catra choked. "Even if you kill me... you'll be outnumbered... the other princesses..."

"Will fall just the same," Prime remarked. "I may not have my clones or my empire but I am nothing if not resourceful. Once I'm finished with you, I'll use the technology in this ruin to bring this planet to its knees once more and then, I shall reclaim what is rightfully mine, the universe you stole from me!"

Suddenly, Prime grunted and dropped Catra, as Glimmer blasted him in the back with a magical blast. The pinkette was a little bruised, but she still had some fight left in her.

"You've hurt my friends enough for one day, Horde Prime!" Glimmer shouted.

Catra gasped for air, sitting up. "Ugh, took you long enough, sparkles!"

"Sorry!" Glimmer groused as she quickly dodged a fusion cannon blast from Horde Prime, teleporting around the room to avoid his shots.

Wasting no more words, Catra quickly joined the fray, and swept Horde Prime off his feet. As he fell, she quickly jumped to her own feet, claws bared, but Prime blasted her back with his weapon again.

"Shame," he said. "I expected so much more from this rematch, little sister." He then dusted himself off. "Be glad I'm giving you a sporting chance by keeping my weapon set to its concussion setting."

Melog then jumped in, trying to claw at Prime, before Prime tossed the alien across the room with his bare hand.

"And don't think I forgot your kind either, Krytisian," Prime scowled. "I should have destroyed your planet if I knew one of your wretched breed survived."

"Melog!" Catra growled, the pain of her memory as Prime's mind-controlled puppet fueling into her rage for him. She was ready to

leap on the bastard and rip his still-beating heart out, if it weren't for Glimmer placing a comforting hand on her shoulder.

"Don't," she warned. "He's just trying to mess with your head."

"I know... he's toying with us, trying to wear us out," Catra added.

"Exactly, now let take care of tall, pale, and misshapen over here, you take Adora out of here and go back to brightmoon to get help," Glimmer ordered, her hands glowing with Moonstone energy.

"Sparkles, no, he'll kill you!"

"My magic gives me more of a fighting chance," Glimmer argued.

"I'm not letting this fucker kill you, Sparkles," Catra insisted. "We're taking him together!"

Prime laughed. "Yes, my dears. Take me on! I've been wanting to test my new body's limits!"

Catra then charged at Prime again, dodging the blasts from his stolen fusion cannon, leaping from a nearby wall. However, Prime then grabbed her by the foot, tossing her to the ground, though Catra was able to get back to her feet and slashed him in the face with the claws on her toes.

Glimmer rolled her eyes and then jumped into the fray, trying to cast a spell to bind Horde Prime to the ground. A magical circle appeared beneath him, chains of energy emerging from it and wrapping around him tightly. But Prime, with his strength alone, easily broke free.

"Fuck!" Glimmer swore.

"I may not have fully overcome my weakness to magic, your majesty," Prime stated. "But I have overcome it enough so your pathetic little spells won't have any effect on me."

"Yeah, but my claws certainly might!" Catra cried, leaping through the air. She managed to slash Prime across the face again, Prime grunting in pain, green blood oozing from the wounds.

Prime screamed, before blasting Catra with the fusion cannon at full power. Gimmer quickly teleported Catra behind a nearby pillar, Prime firing on them left and right as he was temporarily blinded by Catra's attack.

"So much for taking him together!" Glimmer complained.

"Hey, he hurt my girlfriend and your boyfriend!" Catra reminded her.

Prime then blasted the pillar they were behind, Glimmer teleporting them to safety. As they watched the pillar collapse, they noticed the whole structure was starting to shake heavily. Looking at the nearby walls, Catra saw the cracks in them start to grow larger, realising the entire Castle was becoming unstable.

"If he fires that thing carefully enough, he'll bring the whole damn ruin on our heads!" Catra exclaimed.

"Then let me distract him!" Glimmer argued. "I'll drag him down into the tunnels and keep him busy long enough for you to get that thing off Adora."

"Sparkles, that's suicide!"

Glimmer looked down. "Better I die giving my life so my best friend can live. Besides, I'm the reason Prime even found Etheria in the first place, remember?"

Catra sighed. "You're a real stubborn bitch, you know that, Sparkles?"

"It's why you like me, Horde Scum," Glimmer replied.

"Yeah, I do," Catra said with a smile. "Alright... go get 'em, Pinky."

"Oh, don't worry," Glimmer assured, her hands sparking with arcs of magical energy, "I intend to. After all, we have some unfinished business." Clasping her fist in her palm, she popped her knuckles, warming her hand up for the beating she was intending to deliver. "Wish me luck."

Smirking and nodding, Catra ran over to Adora, and picked her up. Melog limped over and grew in size, Catra laying Adora down on her companion's back. Making sure Adora was secure, Catra wasted no time in running out of the central chamber with Melog in tow.. She could have gone back for the others… but Adora was her priority right now.

"What's this?" Prime then noticed Catra and Melog "You are fleeing the battle, little sister? I did not take you for a coward. Clearly, your life as Adora's lover has softened you a little too much."

But before Prime could fire, Glimmer blasted him with her magic again, knocking him off balance slightly. "It's called a tactical retreat, Prime. Not that you did them all that often from what I've heard."

Prime smirked. "Well, well, well, you Etherians are smarter than I gave you credit. Very well, Catra will never be able to free Adora from the Starmind's thrall anyway. I can deal with her later." He then aimed his weapon at Glimmer, the fusion cannon humming. "Any last words? You know how this is going to go, your majesty."

"Just that I will never be able to forgive myself for bringing you here in the first place, you fascist scumbag," Glimmer rasped. "And even if you do kill me, the rest of Etheria will still fight to stop you. We beat you once, we can beat you again."

"How noble, sacrificing yourself to save your precious hero of Etheria." Raising the cannon, Prime pointed it squarely at Glimmer's head. "I'll make sure your death is as noble as your life was futile. It's almost a shame. All of your so-called 'friends' are

mere inches from you, but they as well be on the other side of the planet in their abilities to help you."

"You'll have to catch me first!" Glimmer smirked, before she quickly teleported away.

Horde Prime laughed. "Well then, I suppose I have earned a bit of fun. But rest assured, your majesty, I am an expert hunter. I've been playing this sort of game since before this planet was even formed!"

He then rushed down the hall, chasing after Glimmer. Catra looked over at him from the nearby corridor as she dragged Adora away into one of the other chambers. She hoped Glimmer could keep him back long enough for her to wake Adora up… or they were all as good as dead.

The ride to Brightmoon was peaceful and serene. The sun warmed Adora's face as she rode Swiftwind over the beautiful fields and valleys. The wind blew through her hair, making it whip and flutter behind her, its long golden locks glowing in the warm, soft sunlight.

The entire experience made her feel at peace. But, deep in the back of her mind, an uneasy feeling still nagged her. What was that vision she had earlier, of a war-torn battlefield with her as some kind of knight? Did she imagine it? How could she have imagined it? Etheria had been a peaceful world since, well, forever. There were been no wars, no disasters, not even a famine in all her life, so it was clearly no war she'd ever fought in.

So that just left the question: what exactly did she see? And why did it feel so familiar to her?

She quickly shook her head, forcing the memory back deep into her mind. She didn't need to dwell on something that just wasn't possible right now. Today was her birthday, and after she attended to whatever Glimmer and Bow needed her to attend to,

she'd head right back home and celebrate it with her wife and child.

Brightmoon appeared quickly on the horizon, and standing on a balcony as Adora rode up its massive steps was Bow She waved over to him, getting his attention. However, something seemed, off, to her. It took longer than usual for Bow to notice she was coming and for him to wave back. She was well in sight of him, so he should have been able to reply sooner.

She dismissed it quickly, assuring herself that she was just over-thinking things. Most likely, he had something on his mind and didn't notice her until that moment.

She pulled up to Bow and leapt off Swiftwind. "Hey there, Bow," she greeted merrily.

"Hey Adora," Bow replied with a smile. "Happy birthday, by the way. I'm uh... sorry for taking you away from your family like this, but Glimmer insisted she saw you as soon as you were up."

"It's no problem," Adora scoffed, "if anything, I think you might have saved me." Leaning in close to her friend, she whispered, "I think she was planning a surprise party for me."

Bow whistled innocently. "Oooh is that so?"

Adora raised her eyebrow. "Bow... is there something you wanna tell me?"

"No no!" Bow insisted. "Nothing at all. Anyway, let's head inside and talk."

As the two entered the castle, Bow smiled at Adora.

"So... how's Finn doing these days?"

"Same wonderful little nugget as always," Adora said. "They're still at that stage where they think kissing and the like is gross."

Bow just chuckled as he laid an arm on his friend's shoulders. "Cynthia's the same," he states with a smile. "This morning, Glimmer was feeling especially wicked and talked for hours on end about finding suitors for her."

"What?" Adora laughs ruefully. "She only 10 years old, Bow! Don't you think she's a little young to find a husband?"

"9 and 3/4," Bow corrected. "And it wasn't my idea. Besides, Glimmer was just joking about finding her a husband, …I hope."

Adora laughed ruefully. She had known Glimmer practically all her life, and not once had she been known for her sense of humour. …Had she? She was sure she'd known her friends forever. But, something felt, wrong, if she really thought about it. Thinking to herself, she tried to remember how her and Glimmer met. She remembered woods, and rocks, Adora was caught in some sort of trap, and there was a sword?

Suddenly, a bone-rattling wave of pain shot through her body, her vision faded and doubled, and a horrid screech rang in her ears. She fell to her knees, the pain too much to bear. More visions flashed through her, of her and Bow and Glimmer, all of them fighting together... and... Catra? Was she fighting Catra?

"Adora!" Bow cried as he ran to his friend's side. He helped pick her up to her feet, keeping her steady all the while, but Adora was still shaking. For a moment, Bow thought she was going to have a stroke.

After a minute, the pain faded, and the ringing stopped. Adora blinked a few times to clear out the tears in her eyes. Her breathing was very shaky and her whole body was shivering.

"Are you alright, Adora?" Bow asked cautiously.

"Y-yeah, yeah, I think so," she murmured. "I just need to sit down for a second."

Bow gently guided her to a nearby stone bench, and guided his friends to sit. "I'm going to go get you something to drink, and a tissue or something."

"A tissue?" she asked. "Why? Do I need one?"

Bow sucked in his breath, trying to find the best way to say what was on his mind. "You, um," he murmured, before sighing and just saying outright, "Your nose is bleeding."

Adora reached up, feeling the cold trickle of blood on her finger. Her eyes widened

"Shit, I am bleeding!" Adora exclaimed.

Bow left and quickly returned with a glass of water and a tissue. Adora did her best to wipe her nose, before gulping down her drink.

"Feel better?" Bow wondered.

Adora nodded. "A little... God, I've been feeling weird all day."

"Really?" Bow asked as he sat beside his friend. "Is something wrong? Are you sick or something?" He put his hand on her forehead. "You do have a bit of a fever."

"No, I feel fine," she reassured him before she paused, her strange vision still on her mind. "Except…"

"Except what?" Bow inquired.

"Well," she said hesitantly, "this morning, before I got on Swiftwind to ride to here, I got this really strange vision. I was on Swiftwind, but we were flying, and Swiftwind had wings. We were over some sort of battlefield, and I was in some sort of really cool looking armour, I think. It was really weird."

"The Horde," Bow said, almost hauntingly.

Adora quickly turned towards her friend, looking at him in confusion. "What did you say?"

"I said how odd," he said plainly, "I think I know what the problem is. You're just stressed about this meeting Glimmer has set up. And on your birthday of all days."

"Maybe you're right," she conceded before lying down on the bench. "I need a break or something."

Bow nodded. "I'll go talk to Glimmer, get her to postpone the meeting until your ready. I'll also see if I can talk her into cutting it short so you can relax a little."

"Thanks, Bow," Adora sighed in relief, though she was still a little concerned.

Bow scoffed before gently laying a hand on her shoulder. "Hey, what are friends for?" he asked before departing. "Oh! And I almost forgot... happy birthday!"

"Thanks!" Adora replied as Bow left. "Wait... you already said that..."

Adora got up and rubbed her eyes, trying to put that thought out of her mind. She still had a meeting to attend. She made her way through the halls of the castle, looking around at the suits of armour and paintings decorating the halls. She saw one in particular, of Glimmer on her coronation day three years earlier.

Glimmer's mother, Queen Angella, had decided to step down as Queen when Glimmer came of age. Ruling Brightmoon was becoming rather tiring for her and Glimmer was more than happy to take her mother's place. Angella was still around though, in an advisory manner.

Eventually, Adora made her way to the Queen's study, knowing that she had to get this meeting done, regardless of her condition. After all, it was a royal decree, though Glimmer never really enforced those with her. She didn't care if Bow had already told

Glimmer to postpone things either, Adora was still capable of getting through this meeting.

When this was all over, she planned to head straight back home and lie on her bed and nap until Catra's little surprise party was ready for her.

Entering Glimmer's study, Adora saw her friend looking at a hologram on the table. Glimmer's pulled away from the projection, smiling at Adora. "Adora! You're early!"

"I am? " Adora wondered. That was weird. She could have sworn that the clock outside the room had shown she was right on time for the meeting. Maybe it was fast or something? Old clocks tended to have quirks like that.

Glimmer grinned, walking over to Adora and taking her hands. "Happy birthday, by the way."

Adora smiled fondly. "Thank you... though I wish my birthday was getting off to a better start."

"Sorry for dragging you here like this," Glimmer stated. "But... I needed to talk to you about something." She stood by the table. "Something is happening to Etheria that has me... a little concerned."

"What is it?"

Glimmer folded her arms behind her back. "For the past few days, I've been getting reports all over Etheria of strange phenomena, rifts of magical energy that suddenly appear and disappear randomly."

"Rifts... what sort of rifts?"

"Look on the map," Glimmer gestured, pointing to several arrows on the hologram. "They are pure magical energy from what we can gather. Sometimes they cause things to just disappear... and

then reappear a few moments later. It hasn't done this to people yet as far as we know."

"What do you think they might be?" Adora wondered.

"Entrapta thinks they might be slight instabilities in the dimension of Despondos," Glimmer explained. "Kinda like some kind of interdimensional tremors."

"And... when was the last one of these?" Adora asked again, having a feeling in her gut.

"According to the scanners... half an hour ago in the whispering woods."

"Glimmer... I saw that happen," Adora answered. "I... I must have been caught in that rift and it didn't feel like a tremor at all."

"What?!" Glimmer exclaimed. "What... What did you see?"

"I... I could have sworn I saw myself in the rift, like a different version of myself. Like I was taller and wearing armour and was riding a flying horse. Oh and I think I had really great hair too!"

Glimmer laughed. "Sure you didn't hit your head or something?"

"I'm serious, Glimmer!" Adora raised her voice. "I nearly had a stroke on my way up here because I had these weird flashes, flashes I'm positive had to be connected to that rift. I'm sure Bow told you that already."

"Wait what?" Glimmer realised. "I... I'm sorry, but Bow hasn't told me about anything about you nearly having a stroke."

"That's... odd," Adora said. "He told me he was going to tell you."

"But then again, Adora, for as long as I've known you, you've always felt different. I mean, you literally fell through a hole in the sky when you were a baby. But I'm sure these rifts will stabilise

soon. Everything will be all right, Adora. I promise. You won't have to worry about this again."

Adora breathed a sigh of relief. "Yeah... maybe you're right. I have been working a bit too hard lately. Maybe it's all just getting to me."

"In that case, you could probably do with something to drink," a voice then said to her.

Adora's eyes widened. Walking into the room at that moment... was Queen Angella. Adora gasped as she saw her, gazing in shock. Glimmer's mother smiled kindly at her, bringing a tray with some cups of tea in her arms. The sight of Angella for whatever reason made Adora suddenly feel cold.

"A-Angella?" Adora spoke, a little confused.

"Yes, that is my name," Angella greeted, chuckling. "You of all people should know it by now, Adora. After all, I was the one who found you in the woods all those years ago."

"Right, sorry sorry," Adora apologised.

"You really don't look well at all," Glimmer admitted, looking at Adora's face and feeling her forehead. "If I didn't know better I could have sworn you'd have seen a ghost."

Adora then looked at Angella and then... another flash of light. Now she was standing in a different outfit, in some desolate landscape. She was looking up at Angella, as the pink-haired woman floated above her head, lightning and wind surrounding her, with a shimmering sword in the sky.

And then, as quickly as it came, the vision faded.

"Ugh..." Adora groaned weakly, rubbing her head, throbbing pain surging through her.

Glimmer quickly rushed to Adora's side, helping her to a nearby seat. "Woah, hang on there!" She helped Adora down. "Adora, are you alright?"

"I... I don't know," Adora whispered. "I could have sworn I just had another flash... your mother... Oh, I feel like it's gone now."

Angella felt Adora's forehead. "Hmmm, you do have a bit of a fever. Perhaps you should just rest for a while, Adora. Maybe you'll feel better."

"I hope so," Adora admitted.

Saying nothing else, Glimmer lead Adora out of the study and towards one of the many guest rooms of the castle. As they made their way, Adora couldn't help but wonder something. As they walked out of the study, she saw that the time on the clock had changed. Maybe it wasn't early after all... just what was going on?

"Hey, Glimmer? You said before that I was early. What did you mean by that? I thought I was on time? "she asked. "Why didn't Bow tell you about my fainting spell?"

"Bow?" Glimmer asked in confusion. "How could he. He's outside with Olympia right now, practising her archery." She then pointed to the large central courtyard. "See? That's them over there. They've been at it all morning."

Adora turned her head, and sure enough, there Bow stood, bow and arrow in hand, a young girl of around 14 years old standing right beside him, trying to mimic his posture. She had Bow's brown skin and Glimmer's purple highlights. But... Wasn't Bow and Glimmer's daughter named Cynthia? And didn't she look a bit younger than that?

Adora paused, completely confused. "That can't be," she said quietly. "We were talking just after I got here. I was on my way to see you but then I had a vision, and afterwards, he helped me when my nose started bleeding."

"Wait, you were bleeding?" Glimmer asked in shock. "Yeah, right after the vision" Adora explained. "Everything hurt for a while, my head was throbbing so much and after it stopped, my nose was bleeding."

"You sure you weren't hallucinating, dear?" Angella wondered. "You don't sound well at all."

"To be honest, I'm not sure," Adora admitted. "Something... just doesn't feel right."

Suddenly, she had another flash, without any visions this time. Now she found herself lying on the bed in the guest rooms. She sat up, feeling confused. Where did Angella and Glimmer go? How did she get here? She didn't remember lying down on the bed... had she been asleep?

Before Adora could ask any more questions, the light turned on and the door to the guest room burst open. Catra, Finn, Glimmer and Bow brought in a large birthday cake for her, full of candles on it. Adora gasped in shock, eyes widened. That was... a really big cake.

"Surprise!" they all cheered.

Adora blinked. "W-What?"

"Surprise, honey," Catra laughed as she approached Adora and kissed her on the cheek. "Now, I know you said you didn't want a surprise party, but I couldn't help myself."

"We really got you," Finn declared as they climbed into the bed their mother was resting on. "You should see your face, mom! You look so surprised!"

"Um, yeah, you sure got me," Adora murmured in confusion. Turning towards Glimmer, she gave her a concerned look. "Glimmer, weren't we out in the halls a few seconds ago with your mom?"

"What? No, you've been asleep all afternoon, silly," Glimmer reminded her. "God you really aren't feeling well."

"Maybe... but I swear I had another vision," Adora murmured.

"What?"

"You know? Those rifts?"

Glimmer looked at Adora with a raised eyebrow. "What rifts?"

"The stuff you brought me here to talk about?" Adora wondered. "Those magic rifts that got you worried and I got caught in on my way here."

"I never asked to see you about any rifts or stuff like that," Glimmer explained. "I just asked you here so we could make preparations for the meeting of the Princess Alliance next month... and to distract you from the party planning."

"You should see the party downstairs mom!" Finn chirped. "Everyone is there!"

Adora was still very confused. Why were they having the party here? She was sure that Catra was only preparing a party for just the two of them and Finn. So much wasn't making sense right now and... it made her head hurt. She wasn't sure what was real and what wasn't.

"Um, maybe you shouldn't see it right now," Bow suggested as he gently laid the cake on a nearby table and gently pushed Adora back down. "You seem a little out of it. Maybe you need another hour of sleep."

"I'm with Arrow Boy," Catra agreed as she tucked Adora in. "You're starting to scare me, babe."

"I'm starting to scare myself," Adora concurred, rubbing her head. "I feel like I'm losing my mind or something."

"Don't worry mom," Finn said cheerfully, their smile wide and full. "I'll still love you... and I'll always be here for you, no matter what happens."

Adora chuckled before bending down and gently kissing the top of their head. "I love you too, little one," she said softly. "And don't worry about me. I think I just need some sleep."

Glimmer sighed. "Would it be alright if I asked Perfuma to come up and take a look after you? I just want to make sure you're really better."

"Yeah, yeah sure," Adora yawned as she adjusted her sleeping position to a more comfortable one. "Just, please, tell her to be quiet, will you? I think I feel a headache coming on."

"No problem," Glimmer assured softly. Saying nothing else, the queen of Brightmoon quietly left the guest room, her husband joining soon after. "Come on, Finn."

"I'll make sure nobody touches your presents," Finn declared proudly as they left. "But I make no promises on the humongous cake they made for you downstairs!"

"Wait I have two cakes?" Adora wondered, before she laid back, just wanting to relax.

Catra laughed as she watched their child leave the room. She began to pick herself up, intent on letting her wife relax, when Adora's hand gently took her own. Looking down at her, Catra quickly caught the silent request that was given to her. With a small smile and a nod, she sat down on the bed, her head resting next to Adora's.

"Don't worry, Princess," Catra affectionately whispered before kissing her forehead again. "You've stayed with me my whole life, now it's my turn to stay with you."

Adora sighed. "Thank you... so... when I'm better, you wanna go down to the party together?"

"Oh yes," Catra purred. "I think you're gonna like the new dress I bought for you for the occasion."

Chapter End Notes

> And here is chapter 2! I actually had to split this chapter in half because it was waaay too long and well, it makes the story feel a bit more evened out in places. I'll be posting the next couple chapters over the coming days and... fair warning for tomorrow's chapter, it gets quite brutal.
>
> If you liked the chapter please be sure to comment!

Chapter 3

Chapter Summary

> Glimmer holds her own against Horde Prime, while Adora finally sees through the illusions surrounding her.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter 3

Glimmer panted as she rushed through the darkened halls of the crystal castle. She remembered when she and Adora first met, how they ended up in a ruin just like this. God she wished Adora was there. Because there was no way in hell she was going to be able to defeat Prime without her.

He was bigger, stronger and even deadlier than ever. But even so, Glimmer still hoped she could outsmart him long enough for Catra to wake Adora up. Prime was a tactical genius, but Glimmer had tricks up her own sleeve. She still was the one who nearly won the war for the rebellion after all.. although nearly at the cost of Etheria itself.

"Why are you running from me, your majesty?" Prime's voice echoed. "We have so much to catch up on."

Glimmer ducked into a nearby chamber, panting. She was tired, really tired. Her legs ached, sweat was beading down her brow. She could have just teleported out of there and gotten help... but she had to keep Prime distracted, to buy Catra enough time to free Adora.

"Is that fear I sense in you?" Prime asked her. "Fear of death? Fear of losing those you love? Fear of never living up to your

mother's example?"

"You have no right to talk about her!" Glimmer shouted, finally catching her breath enough to sprint down another hallway.

Prime laughed, his voice echoing through the rock and stone. "You know, I could place you under the thrall of my plant too, Glimmer. Give you a world where your mother never left you, a world where there was no war."

"And let myself believe a lie? Never!" Glimmer snarled. "You're a sick monster!"

"And who led me to your world, hm? Who was the little fool who thought she could win a war singlehandedly that she nearly let a malfunctioning AI destroy her whole planet? Admit it Glimmer." Prime then stepped out of the shadow in front of Glimmer, the Queen stopping in her tracks.

Smirking, Prime raised his weapon at Gimmer. "Etheria is better off without a failure like you." He then fired at her at point black range.

Glimmer screamed, her whole body charging with magical energy. She fired all of her energy at Prime in one single, powerful, utterly destructive blast. The two beams collided in a mix of purple and green light... before Glimmer was the victor, her form was ablaze with magical purple flame.

The blast smacked Prime into a wall with a thud, Glimmer thinking she'd ended him. But as the tyrant rose up again, Glimmer saw that her most powerful attack had only lightly grazed him.

Horde Prime chuckled darkly, an amused smirk on his face. "All that bravado and so much power, and you could hardly leave a mark on me," he chided as he picked himself up and dusted off his shoulders. "I expected so much more from a warrior of your calibre. Clearly, you are still the weak Princess."

"Shut up!" Glimmer shouted as she fired another beam of magic at him. At the same time, Horde Prime raised his fusion cannon. With a content smirk, he fired at Glimmer's beam of magic, easily cutting through it.

Glimmer quickly rolled out of the way before the beam tore through her. Picking herself up, Glimmer made a mad dash down a nearby hallway. Horde Prime just smirked as he watched the so-called Queen flee, laughing all the more, walking calmly and slowly with confidence.

"Ready or not," he said darkly, the fusion cannon humming as it charged. "Here I come."

The cannon fired, Glimmer quickly teleporting into another room to avoid the blast. She groaned, wondering if there was something in the crystal castle she could use to her advantage... And then down a nearby hallway, she saw a room with what appeared to be glitching holograms inside it.

"Bingo," she said, a plan forming in her mind.

"Oh, your majesty~," Horde Prime sang as he walked down the hallways. "Where are you?" He then fired a blast at a nearby wall, blasting a large hole through it.

"Come now," said the tyrant. "Surely you'd like to help me decorate my new fortress! I plan on mounting your head on the wall, next to that vermin, Catra."

But there was only silence to respond to him, which only enraged an egotistical man like Prime.

"What's the matter, your highness?" he goaded, a slight growl in his voice. "Are you too scared to fight me?" Silence fell over his words, almost seeming to mock him.

"I figured as much, after all, you are still just a child, pretending to be a queen." he mocked. "It's no wonder you would rather spend your days playing games. But I grow weary of this little

game. So come out and die like the annoying lesser primitive you are!"

Prime began firing wantonly, destroying anything and everything he could see. His anger was palpable as he destroyed another section of wall, roaring as there seemed to be no Glimmer in sight.

"Etherian scum!" he shouted before obliterating a nearby pillar. "Where are you!?" he roared, his anger reaching its boiling point.

Suddenly, a sharp whistling caught his attention. "Right here, fuckface!" Glimmer called out. Turning towards the voice, prime growled as he saw the young queen stand her ground in the entrance to a nearby chamber. "You want me that badly, come and get me!"

Prime growled as he pursued the queen down the hall, fully intent on finally ending their chase. He tailed her to the best of his abilities, occasionally trying to blast her to atoms, but just barely missing. So caught up in his pursuit was he, that he didn't notice when the hallway and room around him began to glitch.

It wasn't until he stood dead centre in a familiar-looking chamber, the throne room aboard his ship, that he noticed exactly what had happened. "Very clever, using the old castle's memory projection against me!" he chuckled. "But it won't be enough to stop me. My mind is far too strong to be deceived by mere smoke and mirrors. Still, I must commend you, you have made this a very interesting little chase. Few enemies could actually hold my attention for as long as you have."

"I could say I'm flattered about that," Glimmer chimed in. "But you and I both know that I'd be lying."

"I couldn't agree more!" Prime declared. "So let's end this!"

"Yeah, let's!" Glimmer declared as she charged at Horde Prime. She roared in fury as she attacked, brandishing a massive claymore sword behind her. Prime smirked as he fired at her, only

for her to quickly roll out of the way, not once losing any of her momentum. When she was within range, she swung the sword over her head, intent on chopping the mad tyrant in two. Prime rose his cannon up to block the blow, and watched as the massive blade dissipated into billions of tiny particles of light.

"And what kind of weapon was that?" he mocked as he aimed. "Was that supposed to be your best, your majesty?"

"Wrong," Glimmer growled as a massive armoury like the one from Brightmoon began to materialize around the two combatants. With a look of determination, she stood her ground. "I've only just started."

"Oh very impressive. You used your memories to create a holographic arsenal for yourself," Horde Prime remarked. "Perhaps I might chip you instead, and use your brilliant mind to assist in building my empire."

"I'd rather go to hell!" Glimmer growled, grabbing a pair of shurikens from a nearby shelf and tossing them at Prime.

"Terms, accepted," Horde Prime hissed before charging forward and firing a single blast from his cannon quickly dissipated the projectiles. Lowering the cannon, Horde growled as he saw that Glimmer had disappeared.

"I see how this is," he remarked. "Distracting me with your offense to move to a better vantage point. You prove yourself more and more to be a resourceful individual. I would gladly welcome you into my fold. Together, we can conquer any galaxy we step upon, and bring brilliant unity to all. I will even allow you to keep this planet as your own, and through my benevolence, you will bring peace to all life on Etheria."

"No, bringing you here was a mistake I'll regret for the rest of my life... and also you talk waaay too much," Glimmer argued, teleporting behind him, having grabbed a crossbow. She magically

enchanted the bolt inside of it, gritting her teeth. "Tell Shadow Weaver I said hi when you see her in hell!"

She fired the bolt right into Horde Prime's back, blasting him.

Prime grunted in pain, as the bolt pierced through his insides with a sickening crunch, bursting out from his stomach in a fountain of green blood. He collapsed to the floor in pain, clutching in the massive gaping hole in his stomach and panting heavily. Had... Had Glimmer actually delivered the fatal blow?

"A... lucky shot..." he groaned as he coughed up more green blood.

Reaching down, Horde Prime grabbed hold of the bolt, and pulled. He roared in pain as he pulled the bloody ammunition out, gasping as he recovered. Dropping the bolt with a clatter, he picked himself up on shaky legs. "Obviously, we cannot come to equal ground," he panted, clutching his still bleeding stomach.

Turning towards Glimmer, he shakily raised the cannon, letting the charge within it build up to dangerous levels. "Very well then, let's finish this!"

Taking a single step forward, Glimmer stared down the mortally wounded madman, as determined to end the confrontation as permanently. She grabbed a battle axe from the shelf nearby, staring him down. Horde Prime roared, firing his weapon at GLimmer once again.

Glimmer charged at Horde Prime, dodging his blasts. With a swift slash of her weapon, she sliced off Prime's arm and destroyed his cannon, smashing it to pieces. Prime screamed in pain, before Glimmer blasted him in the face and knocked him down flat on his back.

"No bodies to jump to, nothing to save you," Glimmer remarked., raising her weapon, preparing to cut off the monster's head. "This is how it ends, Prime!"

Horde Prime then laughed. "Oh, child... It has barely begun." Suddenly, Glimmer watched in horror as Prime's chest healed itself before her eyes. Then, in another surge of blood, Prime's severed arm regrew itself, the new appendage dripping with green bodily fluid. Before Glimmer could teleport away, Prime grabbed her by the neck, squeezing it tightly and forcing her to drop her weapon.

He got up, the room changing from the armoury in Brightmoon to the purification chamber on his command ship, a group of his clones appearing as holograms and chanting ominously. Glimmer looked around, panic and fear rising within her again. Of course, it wouldn't have been that easy.

"I was merely biding time before I could successfully hack into the system, so that I could recreate this from my memories," Prime explained. "But I gave quite a performance didn't I?"

Glimmer tried to wriggle free, but Prime's hand clenched around her neck even tighter. "Now, I wish to make you pure, your majesty... And all beings must suffer to become pure!"

He then tossed Glimmer into a familiar pool of green fluid, Glimmer landing with a heavy splash.

Glimmer groaned, a furious surge of pain shooting through her side. She assumed most likely one of her ribs was broken, but had no time to do anything about it. Horde Prime walked into the pool beside her, grabbing her by the hair and tugging her violently. In an instant, Horde Prime had an iron hold on her throat, forcing her head under the water. S

Glimmer gagged and coughed, slamming her fist against his arm in a vain attempt to make him release her. All the while, an eerily familiar sound resonated around them as electrical energy surged into Glimmer, electrocuting her. The pinkette would have screamed in agony, had Prime not been squeezing her throat so tightly as he attempted to drown her.

"Just so you know, I find no pleasure in this," Horde said as he held her down. "I do not revel in the suffering of others. Violence is not in my blood. Instead, I only live for peace, I wish to see the suffering of the universe end, but, with such a vast cosmos full of so many different species with different ideals and philosophies, that sadly cannot come to be. Everyone and everything despises that which is different from itself, which, sadly, include those of their own kind with even the slightest difference."

Pulling her out of the electrified pool, Horde Prime gave Glimmer the chance to cough out the green fluid before forcefully turning her towards him. "However, some species are just too stubborn to accept my ways of peace. They are sadly beyond saving. And do you know what I do to those species?"

Glimmer only groaned, the pain she was experiencing overtaking her. "I treat them as any rabid or suffering animal, and put them out of their misery!"

With a roar, Horde Prime threw Glimmer headlong into a nearby wall, dissipating the hologram. As Glimmer slumped to the floor, Prime strode over to her and grabbed her by the shoulders. He smirked wickedly before pushing her down onto the ground. Glimmer squirmed, trying to break free, but Prime's immense size pinned her down.

The tentacles attached to Prime's head detached and slithered around, their needles stabbing into Glimmer's skin. Green fluid was then pumped into Glimmer, her veins turning green and sickly.

"A neurotoxin my dear," Prime whispered. "To weaken you further, but that won't kill you. No, I won't let a simple poison end your wretched life. I want to hear you screaming in agony!"

He then started to punch Glimmer, wailing on her frail, defenseless form. Every blow from his muscular arms made Glimmer cry and grunt in pain, the queen still feeling the burning fire of the poison in her veins.

"All I wanted was to save you!" Prime roared between his brutal blows. "I only meant to bring you peace and unity! But you rejected my gifts! You rejected my light! So you force me to purge this universe of your rebellious filth!"

He then grabbed her by the hair again and then hoisted her into the air. Glimmer screamed as Prime then smashed her into the ground as hard as he could. Glimmer cried out in pain as Prime kept pummeling her, slamming her face repeatedly into the ground, pulling on her hair tightly. As Prime slammed her into the ground one last time he let go... only to place his heel right against Glimmer's leg.

"Now my queen," Prime said mockingly. "To put you out of your misery!"

He then crushed his heel right into Glimmer's leg, the bone making a sickening crack as Glimmer let out a cry that could be heard for miles, the Queen screaming with tears streaming down her face as every possible feeling of pain coursed through her broken body.

Glimmer's scream echoed in the chamber where Catra and Melog had been hiding, Catra still trying to get the plant off Adora's face. Hearing Glimmer's scream made her heart sink. She grabbed the plant tighter, trying her hardest to yank the damned thing off Adora, Melog trying to help as well.

"Adora!" She screamed, tearing up. "Come on! I know you probably like it in whatever fantasy this thing has cooked up for you but you need to let go! Please! SNAP THE FUCK OUT OF IT!"

Catra pulled harder and harder, desperately trying to free her beloved Adora. She was on the verge of panic, if her tear flooded eyes and frantic groaning was anything to go by. She pulled and pulled, but each vine she liberated off of Adora only returned to its previous position and tightened its grip.

"God damn it!" Catra spat as she grabbed another vine. "Let go of her you fucking weed!" she demanded as she pulled another vine. She tried tearing the vine off of her, only for said vine to grow back within seconds. "Goddamn it, what the hell do you want!? What the hell do you want from her? Haven't you taken enough!?"

Melog roared, trying to tear the vine off with her teeth, but it was no effect. Catra eventually climbed down, pressing her forehead against Adora's muscular chest and sobbing heavily. Nothing she was doing was working, it seemed like it was impossible to free Adora from this alien creature.

"I'll take her place!" she pleaded. "I'll let you drain my life force! You can do whatever you want afterwards! Use my corpse as a bed, if you want! Sprout more of yourself, grow on and in me! Hell, you could take complete control of my body if you want! Just, please, give me back Adora! Don't take her away from me again! She promised to stay... she promised to stay…"

She slammed her fist on either side of Adora's chest, and her tears fell to the floor. "Please, Adora...Please, stay... come back to me..."

Adora was dancing. Her hands were around her wife's waist, Catra's were on her shoulders, and all the two of them could see was each other. A warm glow surrounded the pair as they spun themselves around and around, losing themselves completely in the music that was playing.

Nothing had ever made Adora as happy like this, seeing everyone with her, celebrating her and loving her. Looking around the room, she saw everyone dancing with her and Catra, Scorpia and Perfuma, Glimmer and Bow, Entrapta and... wait, who was that tall pale man with her?

Adora shook her head and found herself looking back into Catra's eyes. The two of them leaned in and shared a kiss again, before Adora touched foreheads with her wife again, sighing in content.

She had loved every part of her birthday party, especially the beautiful white and gold dress Catra had bought her.

Though Adora was curious as to where she'd got it from. There was something... familiar about it. But she hadn't worn this before... had she?

A sudden bump behind her snapped Adora out of her trance-like state. "Sorry, mom," Finn apologized, the young cat dancing with a young scorpion girl with blonde hair.

"It's alright sweetie," Adora said as she watched them dance with their girlfriend. Wait, girlfriend? The last thing she remembered, Finn was at the "gross, mushy stuff" phase the last time she knew. Come to think of it... Finn seemed to have grown older since she'd last seen them, they looked around 14 now.

"You okay?" Catra asked as her wife took a half step back.

"I-I don't know," Adora groaned as she began to rub her head. "Something feels wrong again... am I going crazy?"

"Hey, you aren't going crazy," Catra reassured her. "Everything's perfect... Especially you, my princess."

Adora gazed fondly at Catra. Yes, everything did feel perfect... but was it? If everything was truly perfect as Catra said, why was Adora still feeling such a sense of dread, that everything around her was so terribly wrong? Wouldn't she be feeling as though she was on cloud nine once more?

"Yeah, but," Adora said, hesitant to continue.

"But?" Catra asked.

"But, I don't know," Adora groaned. "Something just feels, wrong. Things don't add up. It feels like I'm missing something important. Like; since when did Finn have a girlfriend?"

"Since last year remember?" Catra quipped playfully before bopping her nose with her tail. "We caught Finn and Rosa kissing that one time in their room, and they both begged us not to tell Perfuma or Scorpia." She laughed at the memory. "That was one birthday you wouldn't remember."

"But, that's the thing," Adora "I don't remember."

"Of course you do, dummy!" Catra insisted. "Like remember Princess Prom? It was like our third date after we got together." She grinned. "Here, let me jog your memory."

Catra smirked and then dipped Adora.

As Catra dipped the blonde, Adora's eyes widened. She had another flash. This one, she saw Catra change, her suit changing to a purple and burgundy one and her hair more wild and messy and the expression on her face was not a playful smirk, but something more sinister.

Adora gasped and backed away, fear rising within her. She watched as the form of her wife twisted into shapes she didn't recognise, Catra wearing darker, more sinister outfits, taking on stranger forms. One of them was Catra as she was when they were younger, with half of her body mutated into a dark corrupted form and another was Catra with green eyes and wearing a white robe.

All these sights terrified Adora.

"Adora?" Catra asked in shock. "What's wrong?"

Adora backed away, fearful. "S-Stay away!"

"Adora!" Catra cried out, reaching out to her.

"It's wrong!" Adora cried, stepping back further. "All of this is wrong!"

Without warning, Adora ran away from her wife, shoving past friends and guests to reach for the door and escape. When she reached the large double doors, she grabbed both handles, pulled with all her might, and in a blinding flash of light…

"Surprise!" everyone cheered . "Happy birthday!"

Adora stared in shock. She was back in the ballroom again and everyone was cheering for her, whooping with joy. Hadn't this already happened? Suddenly, she felt like everything was right again and everything was perfect again, all those worries flowing out of her She sighed, feeling Catra kiss her on the cheek.

"I love you, Adora," she whispered.

"I love you too," Adora whispered back before kissing Catra on the lips.

"Happy birthday, mom," a voice said, Adora pulling from the kiss to see a much older Finn smiling at her. They looked to be around 18 now, wearing a black and purple suit with a tie. Adora. felt.. confused a little at the sight of them, but shook her head before hugging them as well.

"Oh, thanks sweetie," Adora said softly.

"Surprised you made it, kiddo," Catra remarked. "Figured you and that girlfriend of yours had gotten lost."

"What, and miss my favourite mom's birthday?" Finn jested. "Mama, be serious!"

"Uh-huh," Catra snarked. "How are you and Flora doing anyway? You haven't really checked in with us since you moved out."

"Oh we're uh... we're doing fine," Finn replied, rubbing the back of their head. "And uhh... Mom, can we talk in private for a sec? There's something I need to ask you about."

"Are you sure?" Adora wondered.

"Hey, you know you can talk to both of us without worry, Kiddo," Catra assured them. "So go on, spit it out. We've got plenty of time."

"I know," Finn assured Catra. "but this is something only mom can help me with." They fidgeted with their pocket, both women's eyes widening as they saw a very recognizable shape hidden within.

Smiling sweetly at her child, Adora took their shoulder. "Ahhhh... I see. Tell you what, Finn, why don't we take this outside. Catra, you won't eat the whole cake while I'm gone will you?"

"Me? Eat a whole cake? Adora, would I do a thing like that? On your birthday?"

"Yes," Adora remarked, folding her arms and smirking.

"God... being married to you is the worst sometimes," Catra snarked. "Alright... but make it snappy you two. My stomach is growling for cake."

Adora giggled and she led Finn to a nearby open balcony, the nighttime sky shining with numerous stars and a brilliant full moon. As they stood outside, Adora took in the peace and quiet for a moment, gazing up at the thousands of stars shining in the sky... but then she began to wonder.

Wasn't Etheria in a shadow dimension? Why could she see stars?

"Uhhh Mom?" Finn wondered and Adora shook her head.

"Sorry," she replied, before clearing her throat. "Now Finn, what's this you need help with?"

"Um, mom," they stuttered, trying to find the words, still clearly nervous.

"It's okay, sweetie," Adora assured gently. "Take your time."

Taking a deep breath, Finn gathered themselves. "Do you remember how you asked mom to propose to you?"

Adora paused, trying to remember. For some reason, she couldn't. It should be an important memory that would never be forgotten, but for some reason, she couldn't. She pondered further and yet... no, no memory of any proposal. But surely, she would have remembered such an event.

"I don't..." Adora murmured in what could be interpreted as fear. She quickly shook herself, pushing the unease down and not wanting to disappoint her anxious child. "Well, it was years ago, it's kind of hard to remember." She smiled cheekily at her child. "This wouldn't happen to have to do with that engagement ring you're hiding in your pocket, would it?"

Sighing, Finn pulled out a small black velvet box and opened it, revealing a beautiful white-gold ring with a single brilliant cut diamond in the center.

"It's beautiful," Adora said sweetly.

"Thanks," Finn said. "I just hope that Flora likes it."

"She'll love it, honey," Adora assured. "I'm surprised you're wanting to get married so young but... well you're a grown-up now, it's your choice after all."

"Yeah, but she makes me so happy... and I know it'll be worth it. I mean, it took me quite a lot of time to be able to afford to buy the ring in the first place," Finn admitted. "Oh and Mom? There is one more thing I want to ask you."

"Yes?" Adora asked.

"I want you to wake up."

Adora was taken aback. Did Finn just speak in Catra's voice?

"Adora please listen to me!" Finn shouted, in Catra's voice. "What you're seeing isn't real! I know it's trying to keep you in there but you need to fight it, no matter how badly you don't want to! Please, Adora!"

Adora screamed and the whole world shifted and glitched around her, day turning to night and back again, her outfit changing from her dress to golden armour and even Finn changing from an adult into a young child again.

"Mommy! What's wrong!" Finn exclaimed.

Adora looked out over the balcony, trying to calm down. Everything in her life was perfect. She had the sweetest friends, the most beautiful wife and the most wonderful child she could ever hope for. But as she looked out from the balcony, she realised something.

Was everything just a little... too perfect? Were there any flaws in this world? She thought for a moment, trying to remember other than today when anything bad had ever happened. When was the last time she had an argument with Catra? When was the last time Finn had gotten in trouble?

"Mommy?" Finn wondered, tugging on Adora's dress.

Adora sighed. "Yes, Finn?"

"Are you okay?" They wondered.

Adora gulped, having just come to her realisation. She turned around, kneeling down beside Finn and taking their hands into her own.

"Finn... did I ever tell you about the day you were born?" she spoke, tearing up. "I... I remember it like it was yesterday. You were wrapped up in all these little blankets... and your beady blue eyes gazed up at me. And your little hand squeezed my finger so tightly."

"W-Why are you telling me this?"

"Finn, I remember so much of my life. From all the times I played with you, to when me and your mama were kids, when me and her shared our first kiss, to the day we got married. But..." She started to cry. "I don't think any of this is real. It's too perfect."

"Of course, it is, Mommy! Everything's perfect!"

"No, it's not!" Adora shouted. "Nothing is ever supposed to be perfect. When was the last time you got hurt? Or me and your mama got really mad at you?"

"Mommy... you're scaring me..." Finn backed away, a look of fear in their eyes.

Adora started to cry. Even if Finn wasn't real, she didn't want to hurt them. They were her own flesh and blood. She pulled Finn close and hugged them. Tears streamed down her face. In order to break free of this, she had to let go. The earth started to shake a little, Finn squeezing Adora tighter.

"Finn... I love you so much," she whispered.

"Hey, what's going on out here?" Catra then said, walking outside.

Finn broke free from Adora, rushing to Catra's side. "Mommy scared me! She thinks I'm not real!"

"What?" Catra wondered. "Adora, have you had too much to drink?"

"Catra..." Adora sighed. "Oh, Catra. Please, don't make this hard for me. I love you more than anything... and letting you go, even for a moment, is going to be the hardest thing I ever have to do."

Catra raised her eyebrow. "Okay, you are drunk. C'mon, Adora. Better get you home. I know what you're like when you get like this." She then tried to grab Adora's hand and pull her away, but Adora pulled back.

"No Catra!" Adora argued. "I'm not going to go. Catra... none of this is real. Us, this world, Finn... none of it is real. I've had this strange feeling all day. That I'm in some kind of dream. But it's not a perfect dream. Something is breaking it down, causing those flashes, those rifts... whatever they are."

"Adora, you're talking nonsense," Catra stated, sternly. "Come back inside, please. You're scaring Finn."

"Finn isn't real!" Adora shouted, tears streaming down her face. "We're not married, Catra, we didn't grow up in Brightmoon! Don't ask me how I know this, but none of this is right!"

"How the hell can you say that?!" Catra cried out, grabbing her by the shoulder. "We have a perfect life here! How can you deny that!"

Adora was about to reply but then she had another flash, this one the clearest she'd had so far. It was of Catra, a different version of her seemingly grabbing the sides of her face, gazing into her eyes.

"ADORA! YOU'RE ALMOST THERE! YOU NEED TO FIGHT IT A LITTLE MORE!" Catra shouted.

Adora was brought back to reality, confident now of what she knew. She then glared at the being before her, the one she saw as Catra.

"Because you're not my Catra," Adora argued. "None of you are real. You're just visions created to distract my mind while the real people I love are out there, dying because I'm not there to save them!"

"You fool!" Catra screamed, her voice sounding more like Horde Prime's.

Adora closed her eyes... and then opened them again, her eyes glowing a bright blue. Suddenly, the ground shook violently, cracks in the earth opening up and purple energy spewing up, the

whole planet seemingly being ripped apart around them. Adora glowed brighter and brighter, as if she was the sun itself.

Holding her hand up high, a familiar golden sword formed in her hand, glowing with magical light.

"NOOOOO!" Catra screamed.

"I'm so sorry," Adora whispered. "For my present to live, this future, this beautiful wish has to die... FOR THE HONOUR OF GRAYSKULL!"

Chapter End Notes

> Chapter 3 now! I apologise for how... well, brutal the fight between Glimmer and Prime was, even I kinda felt uncomfortable writing it... but honestly it was kinda cathartic to write? Anyway tomorrow will be the final chapter. I'll see you there.
>
> If you liked the chapter please be sure to comment!

Chapter 4

Chapter Summary

> Adora finally breaks free... and delivers a reckoning upon Horde Prime, but the evil tyrant has a few tricks up his sleeve.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter 4

Catra grunted as she tried to pull off the alien plant, feeling its tendrils slowly slipping off of Adora's face. She knew Adora was fighting back now but it just wasn't enough. She had to help her break free. She kept tugging on the plant, feeling it gently slip away at last.

"Come on Adora!" Catra cheered. "Just a little more!"

Suddenly, Adora's body glowed with golden magic, as the plant suddenly came free completely. However, Catra was knocked back by a sudden shockwave onto the floor.

As the plant was freed, it wriggled over Catra's body, Catra trying to fight it off... and then everything went dark. When Catra came to... she saw herself and Adora running through a dark, green metal corridor. She recognised it right away... this was the Fright Zone, where she'd grown up.

"Come on Catra!" Little Adora called, to which Catra followed.

At that moment, the memories of her real-life faded away... and Catra was a kid again. She was with her best friend and that was all she cared about in the world. Just her and Adora against the

world, nothing to stop them. But then Adora stopped, seeing a darkened chamber nearby.

Catra's eyes widened. It was Shadow Weaver's sanctum. She felt a sense of fear rise up inside of her, the fur on her tail sticking up in terror.

"Bet we can sneak into Shadow Weaver's lair!" Adora dared.

Catra felt nervous, but she knew that Adora would be at her side. She would protect her. "O-Okay... but you go first!"

"Don't be such a scaredy-cat," Adora teased, giggling. "You go first!"

"I'm not a fraidy-cat!" Catra huffed in indignation. "I just don't want Shadow Weaver to get mad and punish us again!"

"She won't, not if you blame it all on me," Adora admitted. "And don't worry, I won't let her hurt you. I promise."

"You promise?"

Adora held Catra's hand tightly. "I promise." Catra felt safe now and then, both of them turned towards the open door and steeled their courage.

"Together?" Adora suggested.

"Together," agreed Catra.

The girls both approached the entrance, Adora trembling a little. Whether it was in fear or excitement, she couldn't say, but the moment Catra's hand slipped into her own, the trembling stopped.

"Don't be such a scaredy-cat," she teased, causing her friend to laugh a little.

As they walked into the archway, both Catra and Adora gulped They knew that once they were inside the sanctum, there would

be no turning back. With trembling hands, both girls walked into the dark chamber, the aura of the Black Garnet illuminating them both sinisterly.

Adora looked around, feeling a sense of ease. "Heh, we made it."

"Yeah, I thought we'd be goners," remarked Catra.

However, both girls realised they weren't alone.

Standing behind them stood Shadow Weaver, her eyes glowing with anger. "And what do you to think you're doing?" she asked sharply, venom oozing from her words.

Both girls froze in their tracks, petrified with fear.

"You know that entry into my personal chambers is strictly forbidden," their mentor stated as she approached, gliding soundlessly over the metal floor.

"As you should know, that any who dare to breach my sanctum will be swiftly punished." She held open her hand, it glowing with red magic."Now then, whose idea was this?"

Catra was shaking, her eyes constantly flicking back to the energy in Shadow Weaver's hands. She could remember all the times she'd seen a Horde soldier being electrocuted by Shadow Weaver's dark magic, their screams of pain drilling into her skull and haunting her. For the while, she was fortunate to never be on the receiving end of it, but she knew that if she blamed Adora... she'd get punished.

"It," she tried to speak, fear gripping her throat tightly. "I was," she barely muttered. "We were-"

"It was my idea!" Adora stated, catching both parties by surprise. "I dared Catra to look into your chamber with me, and goaded her into continuing when she tried to back out. Catra did nothing wrong! Please don't punish her!"

"As I thought, of course Catra has done no wrong," Shadow Weaver growled. "Because she has been corrupting you! Her presence has distracted you long enough Adora!"

"No! I haven't done anything to her!" Catra argued.

Shadow Weaver raised her hand, locking both Adora and Catra in magical chains. Both girls tried to wriggle free of their restraints, but the chains were made of an unbreakable metal that nothing on Etheria could break.

"I wish I didn't have to do this. But I can't allow this to go on," Shadow Weaver spoke coldly. "Do not worry, Adora. When I am done, you won't even remember Catra."

Floating closer, Shadow Weaver placed her hands beside Adora's head, red magic flowing from them and into Adora. The young girl screamed as Shadow Weaver's dark presence entered her mind, preparing to purge it of all thoughts and memories of Catra. Catra just stared in fear.

But that fear soon turned into rage. No, not again, she wasn't going to let Shadow Weaver hurt either her or Adora ever again.

"No!" Catra yelled, "YOU WON'T HURT HER EVER AGAIN!" She then broke free of the chains of magic and leapt at Shadow Weaver, slashing her mask apart with her claws. As Shadow Weaver fell to the ground, Catra slashed at her scarred face, roaring angrily as her claws dug into grey skin.

"Get... off me!" Shadow Weaver grunted, before Catra stabbed her throat with her claws, hearing her sickening voice croak and wheeze. Finally, Catra slashed at her throat again, black, corrupted blood oozing out as the life faded from Shadow Weaver. But Catra wasn't done, not by a long shot.

As Catra clawed and scratched at her so-called guardian, she could hear her best friend cheering for her. The brave words of encouragement from Adora pushed her to show no mercy.

Catra roared, as she clawed more and more at what was left of Shadow Weaver. The monster deserved to die, for all the pain she'd put her and Adora through. Tears streamed from her cheeks as she kept slashing and scraping, the dark, black blood staining her clothes and fur.

"DIE! DIE! DIE!"

Adora's eyes opened for what had been the first time in what felt like years to her, all the memories of her real life fading back to her. She looked down, seeing that she was transformed into She-Ra again, all the strength and magic coursing through her, her muscles glowing with power.

As she saw her injured friends, she saw a new face had joined them. "CATRA!"

She rushed over to Catra, seeing her lying on the floor nearby with the alien plant stuck to her face. "No... No... no, Catra no! I won't let this happen again!"

Melog crawled over to her and nuzzled her gently.

"Hey Melog, I'm happy to see you too... now let's get this thing off Catra."

Adora grunted, wanting to try and pull it off her but then she heard Glimmer's scream. Panic welled up in her, as for a moment she didn't know who to save first. But eventually, she concluded that Catra would be alright for now. She looked over at Melog, gazing at the alien.

"Keep her safe, Melog, I'll be back," she stated, before taking off.

Adora rushed at full speed through the corridors, magic enhancing her speed. Her whole body looked as though it was on fire, as she burned with rage and anger for what Horde Prime had done. She then rand into the chamber where Glimmer and Horde Prime were fighting.

Prime had Glimmer under his heel still, trying to break her other leg. When he saw Adora standing there, gazing at him coldly, he snarled.

"No! It's not possible!" Prime exclaimed.

"Adora..." Glimmer croaked, weakly looking up at Adora.

SPrinting into the room, Adora charged a massive portion of her magic into her fist, and then clocked Horde right in the face with a mighty battle roar, sending him flying through several walls, his scream echoing the deeper in the ruin he fell. Adora panted, having been wanting to do that for what seemed like an age.

Adora then knelt down, stroking Glimmer's hair softly as she pulled her onto her lap. She was badly hurt, with a black eye and covered in bruises, her outfit torn in several spots and most notably, her twisted broken leg.

"Glimmer?" Adora asked. "Are you okay?"

"I... I'm... My leg hurts," She groaned.

Her body glowing with magic, Adora pressed her hand against Glimmer's leg. Then, a wave of healing energy was channelled into Glimmer's body, mostly healing her wounds, but Adora knew it was only enough to keep Glimmer alive. She frowned, Prime would pay for this, for everything.

"Your leg was broken completely, Glimmer," Adora stated. "I've healed the bone more or less, but you won't be able to do much walking."

"That's... fine," Glimmer groaned, as Adora helped her to her feet. Glimmer summoned her staff, using it as a crutch. "Where's Catra?"

"She... got that weird plant off me, but it attached itself to her," Adora explained. "We'll go back there and get it off her."

"No, Prime still needs to be dealt with," Glimmer stated. "Let me go and take care of Catra. You go handle Prime."

Adora nodded, her expression turning stern. Anger rose up within her, knowing this was finally going to end today. From now on, Prime was never going to hurt anyone ever again. Glimmer quickly teleported away, as Adora strode down the broken walls and hallways to find Horde Prime, stumbling to his feet.

She summoned her sword into her hand, wondering how best she would make Prime suffer. Cut off his head? No, that'd be too swift of an end for a monster like that. Break every bone in his body? Brutal and fitting considering what he'd done to Glimmer, but again, Adora felt that was too good for him.

Prime laughed, smirking at Adora. "You should have let yourself be happy in whatever fantasy the plant created for you, Adora. It was my gift to you."

Adora glared at the monster before her. He had the audacity to laugh at her, even after the hell he put her through!? Had he any idea what he really gave her by trapping her in such a gilded cage?! With a growl, she poured all of her magic into her sword. There was no mistaking her intent in the way she looked at him. She was out for blood.

"I should just kill you where you stand," she declared, pressing the tip of the sword against his throat. He just chuckled in response.

"Oh, you poor, naive child," he goaded. "You already did kill me once. And look what that brought you."

"Do you have any idea what you put me through?!" Adora shouted. "How you used my happiness to torture me?! Control me?! While you were out here murdering my friends?! I don't care if I bring the whole fucking ruin down on our heads as I beat the living shit out of you, because this time, I'm gonna make sure you never come back from this, you son of a bitch!"

"I'm a lot harder to kill now, thanks to this form's regenerative capabilities," Prime remarked. "And besides, even if you did manage to use that magic trick on me as you did last time, I'm strong enough to break free now!" He then lunged up and tackled Adora hard with his shoulder.

Adora was knocked back into a nearby wall, as Prime got to his feet again. The tyrant grabbed a large piece of rubble that had been knocked down, using it as a makeshift club.

"What is it with your Etherians and you rejecting my gifts?!" He remarked. "I set Catra free from her pain, I gave you the future you deserved, and yet you still deny me!"

"Your gifts are nothing but poison, Horde Prime!" Adora spat, wiping the blood from her lip.

"My gifts were your salvation!" he roared before trying to bring down his weapon on Adora.

Acting quickly, Adora morphed her sword into a shield and blocked the attack. He was strong now, not nearly as strong as her, but still powerful enough to take her off guard like that. In the end, she managed to push him off her, punching him in the face again and smashing apart his weapon.

"You call what you did to me salvation?!" Adora roared.

"I would have brought you peace!" he stated, "I would have led you to an age with no war, no segregation, no suffering!" "

You mean no free will, no individuality, and no growth!" Adora retorted as she charged at Horde Prime.

Horde Prime ducked and grabbed Adora, tossing her into a nearby chamber, smashing her straight through a pillar. "You wouldn't understand! Compared to me, you are all still mindless animals! You resort to your more based emotions at the slightest difference! Don't you understand: you are weak! You need me to guide you to salvation, even if you don't know it!"

"Oh just shut the fuck up!" Adora cried out, pulling herself from the rubble and smacking Horde Prime in the face with a double-fisted punch.

The blow sent Horde Prime flying, tearing through the walls of the castle like wet tissue paper. She followed soon after, not letting up on her assault. Her anger fueled a rage she didn't know she had, only quelled by the ruthless blows she delivered upon the tyrant's face.

Prime managed to get the upper hand, deploying his tentacles. Small laser blasters emerged from them and blasted Adora back, knocking her away. However, Adora managed to fight back, rushing at Prime as he continued to blast her with green laser fire.

Seeing an opening, Adora slashed at Horde prime's arm, cleaving it off. As he grunted in pain, Adora slid behind him and slashed off his hair tendrils with her sword, disarming him fully.

"That ought to level the playing field," Adora remarked.

Prime grunted as his arm grew back, laughing. His eyes glowed green. "I don't need those to deal with you!"

He charged forth quickly, fully intent to throttle Adora. But Adora was quicker, and grabbed his throat. Wasting no time, she slammed him into the ground before stomping hard on his shoulder. She heard the shattering of bone beneath her heel as she ground into him harder. Picking him up by his now useless arm, she glared into him.

"That was for Glimmer," she hissed before throwing him into another wall. As he laid against the wall, panting, she summoned her sword again, ready to finish the job.

But then, Prime started laughing again. Just what was so funny this time?

"My dear, Adora, it seems I have one last trick up my sleeve," he remarked.

"Save it, I'm ending this now," Adora said, raising her sword.

However, Prime's eyes then glowed green, as did the walls around them. Suddenly, bolts of green energy shot out from the walls, firing into Adora. Adora screamed in pain, collapsing to the ground, the energy like a poison, corrupting the magic within her body and weakening her.

"It seems some of my old virus still remains here," Prime stated, watching Adora scream in agony.

Adora held her ground, taking as much pain from the energy she could handle. Overtime, though, she began to falter, and she fell to one knee.

"Oh? Submitting already?" Horde Prime gloated. "And I thought you could take more than this. Believe it or not, this is only a fraction of my power. I can do so much worse!" At that moment, he unleashed more power into his energy, surging it through her and making her scream more and more.

Meanwhile, Glimmer attempted to remove the plant from Catra's face, using her magic to cut and pull away any stray vines. All the while, she was forced to hear the pained screams of her friend. Melog tried to help as well, but Glimmer was worried they wouldn't be able to free Catra in time.

"Come on, Catra, wake up," she pleaded as she pried off a vine that grew back, again. "Adora needs you! I don't know what the hell is going on in there, but it can't be more important than the woman you love getting fried out here! So pull yourself out of whatever is going on in there, and WAKE THE HELL UP!"

Catra growled as she slashed against Shadow Weaver's corpse, the black blood staining her fingers. Tears were sobbing down her face as she knew the ordeal was finally over. Shadow Weaver, the abusive monster, was finally dead and she and Adora were safe at last. They were free from their nightmare.

"No more..." she whimpered. "No more hurting Adora..."

"Catra?" Adora whispered behind her. Turning around,

Catra saw her best friend smiling proudly at her. She just stood up to the very bane of her existence and made sure that Shadow Weaver would never harm her or her friend again. The proud look on Adora's face made it all with it, even if she was covered in the witch's blood as well.

Picking herself up, she made her way to Adora, who instantly jumped on her to hug her tightly. "That was so brave of you," Adora cheered.

Catra just scoffed. "It..it was nothing."

"Still, that was pretty awesome," Adora said.

"Not as awesome as you are," Catra replied.

Adora giggled. "That almost sounds like you like me."

"Well..." Catra blushed a little, trying to play it cool. "Maybe I do, maybe I don't... not that it matters right now, dummy."

"Okay... but Catra?" Adora asked. "I just need you to do something for me."

"And that would be? Get rid of Hordak too?" Catra asked smugly.

Adora's eyes glowed a bright purple and a voice very not her own then shouted, an echoing voice that almost deafened Catra. "WAKE THE HELL UP!"

Catra jumped back. "W-what?!"

"WAKE UP CATRA!" the voice repeated. "WAKE UP!"

"Nooooo!" Catra screamed. "I have to protect Adora!"

"Oh? And how do you intend to do that?" A new voice hissed darkly behind her. Quickly turning, Catra froze in fear, as Horde Prime stood before her. He sneered down on her as she tried to attack, only for Catra to find herself as her adult self again, bound by multiple energy cuffs and garbed in a sickeningly familiar white uniform.

"No... not again!" Catra cried, reliving one of her worst nightmares. "Please not again!"

"Do not fear, sister," he said calmly as he fiddled with a nearby console. "Soon, you will be cleansed of all your suffering. You will not know fear, you will not know anger, and you will not know of sadness any longer. All that you will know, will be Horde Prime."

Catra struggled as the platform she stood on began to descend. She felt the chilling wetness before she saw the green fluid of Horde Prime's "cleansing" rising all over her. She struggled hard against the binds, but they still held firm, completely unbreakable.

She looked up and all she could see was Prime's maddening laughter, as his tendrils extended around her, fear overwhelming Catra, the laughter deafening. Catra screamed as the fluid rose above her head, smothering her in the essence of Horde Prime But then, she was showered with a bright light.

Shooting upwards, Catra continued screaming. rising with a start as the last visage of her nightmare still echoed in her mind. Within moments, she knew that this was the real world and all was well again. Her body dripped with sweat, Catra still in shock over what was clearly the worst nightmare she'd ever had.

Glimmer jumped back as well, completely caught off-guard by Catra's sudden scream, but she was thankful that she'd been able to get the plant off now with Melog's help.

"Catra!" Glimmer exclaimed.

Catra smiled a little, but then saw the plant wriggling away on its tendrils, trying to find a new host. Her eyes widened as she saw it

about to leap onto Glimmer. "Sparkles! Quickly! Before it gets you!"

The pinkette nodded. Casting a spell, she ensnared the plant in a magical bubble, trapping it completely before it could attach itself to her. She sighed in relief, knowing that her force field would restrain the plant for now.

"Whew," Glimmer admitted. "That was a close call... you alright?"

"Been better," Catra replied, looking around, "Where's Adora?"

The two of them heard Adora's screaming again.

"We need to help her!" Glimmer exclaimed.

Catra then looked at the alien plant and smirked, knowing exactly what to do. "And I just know how to do it."

After explaining her plan to Glimmer, the pinkette teleported them to Horde Prime's position, watching Adora getting blasted by Prime's virus, green energy surging through her and Prime just grinning wickedly. Catra gazed in horror as Adora, even at her full power, was no match for Prime's advantage.

Prime smirked at them. "Ah, come to watch your love die, little sister?"

"No, I decided to get you reacquainted with an old friend," Catra remarked. "Now. Sparkles!"

Glimmer then grabbed the plant with her magic and chucked it straight at Horde Prime, watching it fly through the air.

"What?!" Prime exclaimed. "NOOOOOO!" His screams were cut off as the plant wrapped around his face, its tentacles burrowing into the holes where his own tendrils had once been. He tried to rip it off, but eventually, its power was too much for him and he collapsed to the ground with a massive thud, his virus dissipating from the walls.

Catra rushed to Adora's side, clutching her tightly. "Adora!"

The blonde hugged her girlfriend softly weakly, pulling her close. "It's alright... I'm okay."

"Thank goodness," Catra whispered.

Glimmer smiled at the two, before gazing at Horde Prime, watching his lifeless body lying on the ground, not even twitching. "What... What do you think he's seeing?"

"Whatever it is," Adora stated as she stood up. "It's too good for him."

Some hours later, Bow and the others had recovered and the other princesses had arrived from Brightmoon to help clean up. Hordak, now that he was up on his feet again, was making sure his unconscious brother was safely secured in a stasis pod Entrapta had brought from Brightmoon.

Glimmer was having her wounds tended to by Bow and Perfuma. She was still going to need a lot of rest, but Bow was just thankful his girlfriend was going to be alright. Scorpia and Netossa were cleaning up the ruins from the battle, Entrapta making note of all the various equipment and First One's tech that had been destroyed.

Adora walked over to Glimmer, smiling at her friend. As Perfuma left Glimmer and Bow to assist Scorpia, she smiled at her resting friend.

"Hey, you look better," Adora replied.

"Sure as hell don't feel better," Glimmer groaned.

"Hey, take it easy, babe," Bow told her. "You did well holding off Prime like you did."

"Well, someone had to look out for the birthday girl," Glimmer remarked. "Happy birthday, by the way, Adora. I wish it was under better circumstances."

"Considering you're safe and sound as so is everyone else," Adora replied. "I'll take it."

Glimmer reached into her pocket, taking out a small box containing her present. "Here, take it. It's a miracle it survived me getting the shit beaten out of me."

Adora opened the box, seeing a beautiful teardrop necklace. "Oh Glimmer, it's beautiful!"

"It's one of my mom's old ones," Glimmer stated. "She used to wear it as a good luck charm."

"Well, it must be lucky considering it survived the whole ordeal it went through," Adora admitted, putting on the necklace. "Thank you... now get some rest... and make sure she does, Bow."

Bow chuckled. "I will."

Meanwhile, Catra was making her way through the area with Melog, still trying to shake the thoughts of her nightmare from her mind. She knew it wasn't real, none of what she'd seen was real... and yet she still felt the pain and fear a little. Melog nuzzled against her, calming her nerves a little.

As she approached Hordak, Catra looked over at the former tyrant, who was gazing at the form of his sleeping brother. Just staring at Prime, even with him in this state, unnerved her.

"What are you gonna do with him?" She asked Hordak.

"Entrapta is going to rebuild my old portal. With it, we'll be able to dispose of him by sending him into Despondos," Hordak explained. "He'll never harm anyone again there, if that plant ever comes off his face."

"Think it will?"

"Doubtful," Hordak replied. "This organism, the Starmind, is from our homeworld. Our species was one of their main prey. And besides, whatever dream it's giving Prime, he's definitely not going to want to escape from it."

"Yeah? Well, good riddance," Catra spat before kicking the stasis pod. She hisses in pain as she tends to her wounded foot, but when she looks at Horde Prime again, she scowled and hobbled away, muttering how good it was to hopefully be finally rid of that monstrous bastard.

Watching her girlfriend hobble away, Adora quickly followed. When she reached her, she quickly picked her up.

"I can walk, you know," Catra stated.

"I know," Adora replied. "But after all we've been through, I'd say we both need some serious pampering."

Adora then nuzzled Catra with her cheek, making her girlfriend blush and nuzzle back, silently agreeing with her.

Walking away from the rest of the group, Catra and Adora quickly found a secluded spot for them to rest. Gently, Adora laid Catra down beside a tree, before joining her, the two relaxing against each other's frames. Catra just sighed, resting her head down on Adora's shoulder.

"Some birthday, huh?" Adora tried to quip playfully. "

Don't try making a joke right now," Catra murmured. "I just want to forget about today."

"I know... I'm sorry," Adora admitted. "I know it must have been hard with that plant thing on your face."

"It was," Catra said. "What did you see in your vision by the way?"

Adora looked away. She felt ashamed of it, how what she wanted had been used against her. Part of her didn't think she deserved that life with Catra now, seeing as how it could easily be ruined and turned against them. "Us... We were together and happy. But I had to give that up in order to save you. And I hated it."

"It's not your fault," Catra admitted. "That thing was messing with your head."

"Yeah, but still, I can't help thinking about it," Adora replied as she gently scritched her lover's ear. "Everything was great: there was no war, all of our friends were with us, Glimmer still had her mom, we were all happy, so much stuff had happened."

"Wow... that's... certainly better than mine," Catra remarked.

"Sorry," Adora apologised. "I'll shut up."

"No, don't," Catra insisted. "You're alright, Adora."

"No, I'm not," Adora argued. "I feel ashamed."

"Why?"

"Because... Because I had to deny what I wanted again," Adora replied. "I swore I would never do that again and yet this time, I had no choice. But what I saw was so perfect. We were married and everyone was happy and... God, Catra we had a child together."

Catra's eyes widened and she blushed. "We did?!"

"Their name was Finn, they were wonderful... I remember everything about them." Adora sighed and started to tear up. "I loved them, my child... And I had to let them be taken away."

"Adora..." Catra spoke. "You can still have that."

"Can I? How can I when I'm scared they could easily be taken away," Adora admitted. "Because I felt so powerless... I may be

She-Ra, but what if we face someone like Prime again, someone who can get under our skin, who knows our weaknesses..."

"Then we'll just fight them harder," Catra insisted, holding Adora's hand tightly.

Catra then stood up. Was this the right time, she wasn't sure. But she was sure of one thing, Adora needed to know how much she was loved. Everyone then looked around at her, staring in awe at Catra as she stood proudly in front of Adora.

"Adora, you are the strongest woman I know. Today wasn't the birthday you wanted, but I will tell you this... you are amazing. You are full of strength, more than just in those big honking muscles, but in your heart as well. I don't know what the future holds, but I do know this. I love you with all my heart and soul and I will protect you and our children and everyone else and be at your side for the rest of my days." She started to tear up. "Because you need to know that you can have that future you saw Adora, and I'll be in it with you."

Adora's eyes widened, the tears streaming down her face. "Catra... are you..."

Catra then got down on one knee, holding out the box with the ring. Miraculously, it had survived the battle as well. "Adora... will you marry me?"

Tears streamed down Adora's face. She couldn't find the words, but in this case, words didn't need to be said. She already had her answer. She jumped up, grabbed Catra and kissed her deeply in front of all of their friends. Everyone cheered and Adora was happy, happy that she now had a future with Catra set in stone.

And despite all that had happened... this was still the best birthday Adora had ever had.

Chapter End Notes

Happy birthday Adora! And so this lovely little tale ends. The stuff with Shadow Weaver and Catra... i know at least one of you predicted something like it, but it was very brutal to write. But I like how I ended this story, on a bright future for our fav girls.

Anyway, if you liked this chapter and the story as a whole, please be sure to comment!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!